

UNIT 5 : Place and role of women in American and British society.

Definitions

Patriarcha : greek *patriarkhès* : *patria* = family, father land & *arkhé* = sovereignty, authority
⇒ power coming from the father and descending from the father.

Dates

1908 : the Uprising of the 20.000 → clothing industry

February 28th 1909 : National Women's day → collaboration of the SP

1910 : Socialist Women's conference in Copenhagen → Clara Zetkin proposed the International Women's Day

1977 : recognised by the UN

1534 : Act of Supremacy : God

1534 : First Succession Act → declared Mary illegitimate

1536 : Second Succession Act → Mary et Elisabeth = illegitimate + offspring

1537 : Third Succession → if Edward dies, Mary = 2nd in line and Elisabeth 3rd.

1750s : The Bluestocking Society (GB) = Literary circle which favoured women's education.

New Jersey :

- **1776** : first state constitution → franchise was given to men and women, but subsequent to the wealth you had (property).
- **1807** : election reform → over with the property requirement but they excluded women and blacks.

1832 : First Reform Act → franchise to middle-class male people.

1833 : Slavery Abolition Act GB

1840 : World anti slavery convention GB

1848 : Seneca Falls Convention US

1857 : The Matrimonial Causes Act : divorce = Special Courts

1867 : Reform act

1870 : The Married women's property act GB : money they earned, inherit property (married)

1872 : the National Society for Women's Suffrage (GB) First.

1897 : the National Union of Women's suffrage society (GB)

20 =/ societies, Pr = Millicent Garrett Fawcett (sister), suffragist.

1903 : the Women's Social and Political Union (suffragettes) (GB)

Pr = Emmeline Pankhurst, suffragettes → hunger strikes, assault, vandalism

1916 : National Women's Party : front of the white house, "Silent sentinels" (Mott)

1918 : Wilson's Address : women's role = vital to the war effort

June 4th, 1919 : 19th Amendment passed → ratified on August 1920

1918 Representation of the People Act : Conditions (30 ans...) GB

1928 : Equal Franchise Act : women over 21, same terms as men GB

1965 : pill in the 50 states authorised (1972 : non married women)

July 2023 : US → pill without prescription

1967 : abortion act UK

1973 : Roe v. Wade Supreme court ruling US

1964 : Civil Rights Act, not only for women, but also for minorities (end of segregation)

- a chapter about the Equal Employment Opportunity Commission
- no longer segregated jobs

1966 : Betty Friedan founded NOW (National Organisation for Women) for equal access to education.

1985 : creation Guerilla Girls (anonymous group of feminists) in NYC → fighting against sexism and racism in the art world. To remain anonymous : gorilla masks and pseudonyms

2006 : creation #MeToo

2017 : spread.

WW1 : men took back their jobs but 1930s = great depression → difficult to find jobs.

WW2 : vision of the woman = housewives in the US

→ reconstruction so, huge campaign to ask for workers (migration & women).

1948 : Windrush generation = ship from Jamaica coming to GB.

British women in the 1970s : husband's permission to borrow money, 26 female MPs over 650, domestic violence not a crime, divorce = man got the child custody.

⇒ 1) political rights, 2) social, 3) sexual liberation

First Wave = 1848-1920

Second = 60s-80s

Third = 1990s (international, Butler)

Fourth = nowadays

Concepts / Persons

Doctrine of Coverture : when a woman married, her property and legal rights were transferred to their husband → they lost their id, recognised by their husband's names.

Declaration of sentiment : denounces, claims that men = women.

Brontë sisters = Bell.

Suffragettes VS Suffragists

Force-feeding

19th Amendment : « *The right of citizens of the United States to vote shall not be denied or abridged by the United States or by any State on account of sex. Congress shall have power to enforce this article by appropriate legislation.* »

Glass ceiling

Pill, right to divorce

U.K. : WLF (Women Liberation Front) 7 demands

- equal pay
- equal education
- 24-hour nurseries
- free contraception and abortion on demand
- legal and financial independence
- right to self-defined sexuality
- improved domestic abuse support structures

Generation Xers :

- born in the 1970s
- television-saturated society
- critical of the lack of equality, not only gender equality

Female Xers : beginning of AIDS and women wanting to talk about their sexuality, first TV series and programs for children with a heroine (important women).

Sexual harassment, body shaming, rape culture

→ linked with the evolution of social medias

#MeToo Movement :

- launched in the U.S. in 2006
- assist victims of sexual violence
- widespread in 2017
- sharing experiences on social media

→ Florence Nightingale

Manager and trainer of nurses during the Crimean War

→ Improving hygiene, she helped reduce the death toll.

After the war : first nursing war.

She wrote 200 books : simple english to be understood (medecine)

→ Elizabeth Garrett Anderson

First to qualify as a physician (Medical Practitioner) & a surgeon.

Nicknamed "The woman with a lamp" (The Times for the first time) → Newspaper made her famous.

→ Esther Peterson

Director of the Women's Bureau of the Department of Labour

Called out Kennedy in 1961 to act against discriminations at work regarding women

→ Kennedy created a Commission on the Status of Women with Eleanor Roosevelt, in charge of the statue of women at work ; rendered conclusions in 1963 : "women are discriminated against in virtually every single area of American life"

→ Mary Quant

Created the mini skirt and short-haired style in the 1960s

References

- The Epistle of Paul the Apostle to the Ephesians 5 : 22-33 : the woman has to submit to her husband.

- Patriarcha, Robert Filmer, 1680 : justified divine right historically and philosophically speaking, government of a family modelled on governments
- Malthus, Essay on the principle of population : link between female reproduction and political economy ; he favoured late marriages to lower birth rate.

- Mary Wollstonecraft, Vindication of the Right of Men, 1790 :
 - tradition = barbarism → Most ancient tradition = strongest > weakest. She accused E. Burke to oppose progress
 - importance of love in a family
 - property ownership should be contingent on ability

Vindication of the Right of women (1792) : ***"My own sex, I hope, will excuse me, if I treat them like rational creatures, instead of flattering their fascinating graces, and viewing them as if they were in a state of perpetual childhood, unable to stand alone."***

- Women have sunk below the standard of rational creatures → they are reified.
 - Women have been fully complicit partners → they do not behave correctly, they should do something.
 - Men are naturally stronger by nature but nothing to do with gender equality about intelligence (witty = percutant).
 - They are equal rational creatures.
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- J. Bentham, Critical Assessment :
 - H. Bushnell, Women's suffrage : the reform against nature : *"Is not the man as visibly head of that oneness as any headset upon two shoulders was ever head of the body ?"*
 - Kate Chopin, The Awakening : daring : woman who discovers her body and sexuality. *"Fictitious self which we assume like a garment with which to appear before the world"*.
 - Betty Friedan, The Feminine Mystique 1963 : criticises the cliché of the fulfilled housewife, carried out a survey among educated women 20 years after they left college
⇒ launched the 2 nd wave of feminism
 - Judith Butler, Gender trouble 1990 : philosophical essay, claimed that men and women were different by nature, and that the term "woman" was a social construction (cultural and not natural concept).
- "Gender studies" at university.
- Eve Ensler, The Vagina Monologues 1996 : explored women's feelings about sexuality, different women talking of different women's sexuality problems.